IPS officer said in Jharkhand.

So far, the NIA has conducted multiple raids in four states. Searches were conducted at more than 12 places in Dhanbad, Seraikela-Kharsawan and Ranchi in Jharkhand; Patna, Chhapra and Gaya in Bihar; Chandauli in Uttar Pradesh; and Bardhman in West Bengal. Unaccounted-for cash, digital devices, pilfered ammunition boxes and other incriminating material have reportedly been recovered.

This, incidentally, is not the first time the NIA is probing the suspected role of government personnel and security agencies in gunrunning for the Maoists. In June 2021, the central agency had filed a supplementary chargesheet in a case involving employees and ex-employees of the Central Ordnance Depot (COD) in Jabalpur in Madhya Pradesh. They were suspected of having conspired with a group of arms smugglers and had stolen a large number of AK series rifles, their parts and ammunition. Purshottam Lal Rajak, an ex-armourer of COD, was identified as the kingpin. So far, 22 AK-47s have been recovered from the weapons stolen and supplied to arms smugglers from Munger, Bihar, which were then sold to Naxalites and criminals.

Given that the NIA has taken over the current case, not many details are likely to come out now. The Jharkhand police, too, are keeping their cards close to the chest. For instance, while Vishal Pandey, officer-in-charge of the Jharkhand anti-terrorism squad, has submitted his statement on how 700 live rounds were supplied to Maoists and how 450 INSAS bullets were hidden near a tree, there is nothing on record about their source.

If the recovered cartridge is a "prohibited bore, it almost certainly points to the security forces," says a senior IPS officer

TRACKING THE PILFERAGE

With no manufacturing facilities of their own, the Maoists have no choice but to rely on security forces conduits for arms and ammunition. The gunrunning business thus is based on legally produced cartridges made in government ordnance factories. Every cartridge made there, therefore, carries a head stamp, which links it to the ordnance factory it was produced in, and the security agency it was subsequently assigned to. Even so, in a majority of seizures in the past, attempts to trace the origins of the pilferage have led to dead ends. "If the bullets recovered are of non-prohibited bore," says a senior IPS officer, "there is a chance the Maoists may have procured it from gun licence holders among the public. But if it is a prohibited bore, it almost certainly points to the security forces."

There is no dearth of money either for the Maoists, even though their area of influence has reduced considerably. In September 2021, the Centre officially claimed that the geographical influence of the Maoists had contracted to 41 districts in 10 states, a sharp fall from 96 districts in 10 states in 2010. But according to unofficial estimates, allegedly based on data recovered from Kishanda, the Maoists still manage to raise as much Rs 1,000 crore a year (official estimates say Jharkhand's Maoists, with some 2,000-plus cadre, alone run an extortion empire that yields more than Rs 100 crore annually). The money is essentially used to run their parallel jungle governments, buying arms and ammunition, medicines, funding the legal cases of jailed comrades and, of course, paying salaries.

The security agencies have their task cut out—to plug the gaps and eliminate Maoist links with government armouries. The various central authorities, too, need to improve vigilance as a growing body of evidence suggests that they may have papered over slippages in the auditing of ammunition. Else the scourge will only grow, and feed armed insurgency. ■

A DEADLY TIMELINE



NOV. 11, 2021: Jharkhand police arrest MCC founding member Prashant Bose alias **Kishanda**, retrieve a 2TB data drive that reportedly contains explosive details about Maoist activities

NOV. 13: CRPF constable **Awinash Kumar**, two others arrested for supplying ammo to Maoists. On Nov. 14, 450 live rounds recovered, one more arrest in Ranchi



NOV. 17: Ex-BSF constable Arun Kumar Singh a.k.a. Fauji arrested from Shahpur in Bihar; 909 live rounds of 5.56 bore recovered

DEC. 9: NIA takes over probe. Raids on Dec. 29 at 12 locations; cash, incriminating documents, ammunition boxes found

NOV. 22: Raids in Ferozepur, Punjab. BSF head constable Kartik Behra arrested with 8,304 rounds

NOV. 20: Raids in Buldhana district of Maharashtra; three arrests, 14 pistols and 20 magazines found